

Qualitative Research Designs

120 minutes · 6 self-check questions

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The major qualitative traditions, the data collection methods attached to each, and how rigour is established when the aim is understanding rather than measurement.

Learning objectives

- Distinguish phenomenology, grounded theory, ethnography, case study and narrative inquiry
- Match a qualitative tradition to a research question
- Design an interview guide and a focus group schedule
- Explain sampling logic in qualitative work and the concept of information power
- Apply the criteria of trustworthiness and explain reflexivity
- Recognise when a qualitative design is the right answer and when it is an evasion

The major traditions

- Phenomenology — describes the lived experience of a phenomenon; asks what it is like to live through this; small purposive samples, in-depth interviews
- Grounded theory — builds theory from data through constant comparison and theoretical sampling; data collection and analysis proceed together
- Ethnography — describes culture and practice through prolonged immersion and participant observation; fieldnotes are primary data
- Case study — examines a bounded system in depth using multiple data sources; may be single or multiple case, and is strong for "how" and "why" questions
- Narrative inquiry — treats the story itself as the unit of analysis, attending to how people construct accounts of their lives
- Descriptive qualitative — a legitimate, atheoretical option when the aim is a straightforward account of views and experiences

IN PRACTICE

Choosing a tradition commits you to its sampling, data collection and analysis. Claiming grounded theory and then running six interviews with thematic analysis is a mismatch examiners look for specifically.

Data collection

- In-depth interviews — best for sensitive topics and individual experience; typically 45-90 minutes
- Focus groups — 6-10 participants; strong for surfacing shared norms and disagreement; poor for sensitive or stigmatised topics
- Participant and non-participant observation — captures what people do rather than what they say they do
- Document analysis — policies, records, media; unobtrusive and useful for institutional questions
- Photovoice and participatory methods — shift some control to participants and suit community-based work
- Triangulation combines sources or methods so that a finding does not rest on one type of evidence

Interview guides

- Structure the guide in funnels: open broadly, then probe specifics, then close
- Ask open questions — "tell me about...", "walk me through...", "what was that like?"
- Avoid leading questions, double-barrelled questions and jargon
- Plan probes in advance: "can you say more?", "what happened next?", "can you give an example?"
- Six to ten main questions is usually enough for a 60-minute interview
- Pilot the guide and expect to revise it — this is a strength, not a failure
- In focus groups, plan how you will manage a dominant speaker and draw out quiet participants

Sampling and sample size

- Sampling is purposive: participants are chosen because they can illuminate the question, not to represent a population statistically
- Maximum variation sampling seeks diversity; homogeneous sampling seeks depth within a defined group
- Theoretical sampling, specific to grounded theory, selects the next participant based on what the emerging analysis requires
- Snowball sampling reaches hidden populations but tends to stay within one network
- Saturation is the point where new data generate no new codes or themes
- Information power is the more defensible modern concept: narrow aim, dense sample specificity, strong theory and strong dialogue all reduce the number needed
- Typical ranges: 6-12 for a homogeneous phenomenological study, 20-30 for grounded theory, but justify rather than cite a number

IN PRACTICE

Declaring saturation after a fixed number of interviews planned in advance is not saturation. Saturation is something you observe during analysis and must be able to evidence.

Rigour and reflexivity

- Credibility — do the findings represent the participants' reality? Supported by member checking, triangulation and prolonged engagement
- Transferability — could findings apply elsewhere? Supported by thick description of context so readers can judge
- Dependability — would the process be consistent if repeated? Supported by an audit trail
- Confirmability — do findings follow from the data rather than the researcher's preferences? Supported by memos and reflexive notes
- Reflexivity means recording your own position — profession, assumptions, relationship to participants — and how it shaped the work
- Generalisability in the statistical sense is not the aim, and apologising for its absence misunderstands the design

Worked examples

The same topic in four qualitative traditions

The topic is the experience of women living with obstetric fistula. Four traditions would produce four genuinely different studies.

1. Phenomenology: what is it like to live with fistula? 8-12 in-depth interviews, focused on lived experience.
2. Grounded theory: how do women come to seek or avoid repair? Theoretical sampling, constant comparison, ending in a theory of care-seeking.
3. Ethnography: how does the community treat these women? Months of observation in a village, fieldnotes as primary data.
4. Case study: how did one repair programme work? Interviews, records, observation and policy documents on a single bounded programme.
5. Each demands its own sampling, data collection and analysis. You cannot claim one and execute another.

The point: Name your tradition and then live by its rules. "Grounded theory" followed by six interviews and a thematic analysis is the mismatch examiners look for first.

Rewriting an interview guide that will not work

A student's first interview guide opens with: "Don't you agree that the long waiting times and rude staff are the main problems at this clinic?"

1. It is leading — it supplies the answer the interviewer expects.
2. It is double-barrelled — waiting times and staff attitude are two different things.
3. It is closed — it can be answered "yes", ending the topic.
4. It opens on a complaint, before any rapport exists, which shapes everything that follows.
5. Rewrite: "Tell me about the last time you came to this clinic. Walk me through the day." Then probe: "What was the waiting like?", "How did you find the staff?"

The point: Open wide, then narrow with probes. Pilot the guide on two people — you will change it, and that is a sign the piloting worked, not that the guide was bad.

Key terms

Purposive sampling

Selecting participants deliberately for their capacity to inform the research question.

Saturation

The point at which further data collection yields no new codes, categories or themes.

Information power

The principle that the richer and more specific the sample and aim, the fewer participants are needed.

Reflexivity

Systematic attention to how the researcher shapes and is shaped by the research.

Thick description

Detailed account of context and meaning sufficient for a reader to judge transferability.

Triangulation

Using multiple sources, methods or investigators to strengthen confidence in a finding.

Audit trail

A documented record of decisions taken through the research, allowing the process to be followed.

Activity

Draft a six-question interview guide for your own topic. Swap with a partner, who must flag every leading, closed or double-barrelled question and rewrite one of them. Then role-play the first two questions and note where the guide fails in practice.

Further reading

- **Braun & Clarke — Successful Qualitative Research** — Practical, opinionated and reliable throughout.
- **Malterud, Siersma & Guassora (2016) — "Sample Size in Qualitative Interview Studies"** — The information power concept; short and worth reading in full.
- **Lincoln & Guba — Naturalistic Inquiry** — The origin of the trustworthiness criteria.
- **Creswell & Poth — Qualitative Inquiry and Research Design** — Compares the five traditions side by side.

Self-check questions

1. A researcher wants to build a theory of how nurses develop resilience, collecting and analysing data simultaneously and choosing later participants based on emerging categories. This is:
 - a. Phenomenology
 - b. Grounded theory
 - c. Ethnography
 - d. Narrative inquiry
2. Focus groups are a poor choice for which topic?
 - a. Community attitudes to a new clinic
 - b. Individual experiences of intimate partner violence
 - c. Shared norms about handwashing
 - d. Reactions to a proposed health policy
3. "Don't you think the long waiting times are the main problem at the clinic?" is flawed because it is:
 - a. Too open
 - b. Leading, and also closed
 - c. Double-barrelled only
 - d. Appropriately probing
4. A student writes: "Saturation was achieved as 15 interviews had been planned." This is unsatisfactory because:
 - a. Fifteen interviews is too few
 - b. Saturation is observed during analysis, not decided by a prior plan
 - c. Saturation applies only to grounded theory
 - d. Saturation requires at least 30 participants

5. Providing detailed description of setting, participants and context primarily supports which criterion?
- a. Credibility
 - b. Transferability
 - c. Dependability
 - d. Confirmability
6. A qualitative thesis states: "A limitation is that findings cannot be generalised to the wider population." The best response is that this:
- a. Is an appropriate limitation to acknowledge
 - b. Misapplies a quantitative criterion; transferability is the relevant concept
 - c. Means the sample size was too small
 - d. Requires a statistical power calculation
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Answers

- 1. **b.** Simultaneous collection and analysis, constant comparison and theoretical sampling are the defining features of grounded theory, whose explicit aim is to generate theory.
 - 2. **b.** Stigmatised or sensitive individual experiences are unlikely to be disclosed in front of peers, and disclosure could put participants at risk. In-depth individual interviews are appropriate here.
 - 3. **b.** It supplies the answer and invites agreement, and it can be answered yes or no. "What is it like attending this clinic?" opens the topic without directing the response.
 - 4. **b.** Saturation is an empirical observation that new data are producing no new codes. Announcing it because a planned number was reached inverts the logic and cannot be evidenced.
 - 5. **b.** Thick description lets readers judge whether findings might apply in their own setting, which is how transferability works — the reader makes the judgement, not the researcher.
 - 6. **b.** Statistical generalisation was never the aim of the design. Framing its absence as a limitation suggests the researcher has not understood the logic of the method they used.
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